

A Friend in the Bed

T.S

"I had a great day at school today Mum! I learnt a new word!

Inhabitant!"

"Wow, do you know what that means?" I asked.

"Um, I'm not sure I remember. But I can use it in a sentence!

There's something inhabiting my room!"

A gust of freezing air slapped my face. I felt a huge pain in the front of my forehead and shook myself to clear it.

"Very good! Although, I think you mean there's *someone* inhabiting your room.

Not *something*."

Lily turned to look at me, tilting her head to the side, and it began bending, descending down, no, past her shoulder.

I blinked. In an instant it had snapped back into place.

"No. I mean something. You should go take a look."

"I beg your pardon?"

"Go on, take a look." She repeated.

I laughed, trying to disperse the nervous tension. Lily had always been a ... unique child.

"Maybe we should spend some time on the couch, or do you have any toys ..."

"It scares me. So, so much. Why don't you look Mummy and make me feel better?" Lily may have been whinging, but there was a half smile on her face, as if she was playing a silly joke.

Maybe she was.

"Ok, let's go together. I'll show you there's nothing to be scared of."

"Ok!" Lily grabbed my hand and led me up the carpeted stairs, to her bedroom, a rainbow unicorn glued on the front.

I pushed the door open and turned the light switch on. Pink curtains were drawn over the windows. A desk full of crayons and paper sat next to a single white bed. I turned back to her.

"See there's nothing ..."

The lights blinked off.

I froze, losing sight of my daughter. Then went to turn the switch on. Its click did nothing. I flicked it again.

And again. Rapidly I began moving it up and down, for some reason, a strange anxiety was beginning to grip me.

I turned back to look into the room.

The darkness was extreme, a wall of yawning black.

"Lily? Where are you?"

"Ergggghhhhh." The sound pierced into me. It was a moan, deep, long and repetitive, coming from the bed. It wrinkled my skin, as if my very flesh was recoiling at the moans.

Wet sounds began to slop onto the floor. I started hearing the noises come closer.

"Lily?! Where are you!?" I screamed. I rushed back the way we came.

Until the door slammed into my face.

"Lily?!" I howled, slamming my fists onto the wood in desperation.

I could barely hear her voice through my own frantic efforts to escape.

"I need you to meet my friend! You will grow to love it soon!"

"Please, Lily you need to ..." I stopped.

I felt ... moisture on my shoulder. A cold, pulsating *thing* slowly caressed my back, tickled my hip and wrapped itself around my leg.

I was dragged screaming away, that consistent moan drilling into my brain.

